



ASTHMA

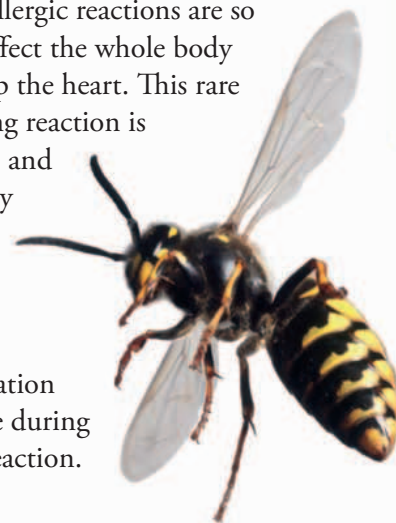
This allergy is triggered by allergens in the air and it affects the airways leading to the lungs. During an asthma attack, muscles in the walls of the airways suddenly tighten, making breathing harder. The airway walls also become inflamed and produce thick mucus, making matters worse.

► **INHALER** *An asthma sufferer uses an inhaler to deliver a drug to his lungs. The drug relaxes muscles in the lungs, making breathing easier.*



RARE BUT DEADLY

In some people, allergic reactions are so severe that they affect the whole body and may even stop the heart. This rare but life-threatening reaction is called anaphylaxis and can be triggered by insect stings. Some people with an allergy to insect stings carry emergency medication at all times for use during an anaphylactic reaction.



TESTING FOR ALLERGIES

Some people suffer allergic reactions without knowing what the cause is. To identify the culprit, doctors carry out skin tests. A range of potential allergens—such as pollen, pet fur, or a foodstuff—are put on the skin. The skin is then monitored to see if it swells, reddens, or itches.



► SKIN TEST

A drop of fluid containing a potential allergen is put on a marked patch of skin.